Catalysts for Revolution: 20th Century Latin America

To what extent did prolonged unequal US-Cuban relations produce the conditions for revolution in Cuba between 1895 and 1953?

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Table of Contents

Introduction **1**

US-Cuban relations 2

Washington's political control over Cuba 2

Washington's dominance over the Cuban economy 6

Cuba's internal weaknesses **10**

Political instability within Cuba 10

Internal structural economic weaknesses 13

Underlying nationalistic mobilisation of society **15**

Conclusion 18

Works Cited 19

Introduction

The attack upon the Moncada barracks on July 26th, 1953 (Pérez-Stable 52) formed a monumental event in Cuban history. Led by Fidel Castro and 136 other conspirators (Sweig 20-21), the revolt, at first glance, merely constituted a failed putsch against Batista's dictatorship. Nevertheless, with historical hindsight, it far more significantly comprised the culmination of brewing nationalistic revolutionary sentiment within Cuba: a watershed in Cuba's revolutionary path that enabled the rise of Castro by 1959 (Gott 147).

Cuban revolutionary fervour first arose in the 19th Century through desires for independence from Madrid's subversive colonial rule, sparking thirty years of revolution that culminated in the 1895-98 Independence War (Lievesley 39). Concurrently, Jose Martí, the "intellectual author" of Castro's nationalist Cuba (Gott 150), forewarned the "monster" of budding American power over Cuba (Sierra) as annexationist sentiments permeated within the elite to secure Cuba's future in the wake of emancipation from Madrid (Pérez-Stable 21). Though annexation never occurred due to post-independence developments, Washington inaugurated the new Cuban republic through the 1902 swindled election (Gott 113) under Estrada Palma, a pro-annexationist Moderate (Kapcia 62), embedding the American foothold over Cuba.

Prolonged American political and economic control determined Cuba's development following imperial liberty, destabilising the Cuban polity while stagnating critical economic reformism (Gott 89) to ensure the continued prosperity of American economic interests. This stymied the achievement of true independence, spurring near-ubiquitous nationalistic frustration that culminated in 1953 preceding the impending 1959 revolution. Nonetheless, other factors, such as fundamental flaws of the Cuban polity, economy, and underlying nationalistic mobilisation, engendered visceral support for Castro's revolutionary policies by

1953, as disillusionment mounted due to Cuba's failure to institute a conducive, wholly independent republic.

Thus, though often overlooked in favour of 1959's scholarship, Castro's failed 1953 coup warrants analysis for its insight into the rising torrent of potent Cuban revolutionary nationalism amidst foreign and internal grievances. Hence, this essay will investigate the extent to which revolutionary conditions emerged within Cuba between 1895 – the start of the final independence war to extirpate Madrid; the birth of the republic – and 1953 due to the US-Cuban dynamic, against internal weaknesses and developments. In evaluating this, two divergent historical branches emerge across expansive colonial, republican, and postrevolutionary primary and secondary sources: American culpability spurred anti-Yankee nationalism, heralding revolution; Cuban forces perpetuated foreign dominance and internal strife, catalysing nascent nationalistic strata to revolt.

US-Cuban relations

Washington's political control over Cuba

Washington had long opposed Cuban independence (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 84). Following intervention from April 1898 (Sweig 10) and exclusive negotiations with Madrid, the island was relinquished to Washington (Benjamin 61), triggering military occupation and American hegemony until 1902 (Horowitz 58-59). Unilateral intervention inflamed nationalistic turmoil amongst Cuba's revolutionary camp: imperial control virtually transferred to Washington, barring *Independentistas* from assuming power. Concomitantly, Washington refused to recognise the Liberation Army, Cuban Revolutionary Party, and Provisional Government, exclusively granting subordinate government positions to leaders who accepted occupation, eventuating in *Independentista* dissolution (Benjamin 62). Deprived of local leadership, Cuba was abject to American control in constructing the institutions of its 'independent' republic (Lievesley 45), entrenching foreign dominance and intensifying nationalistic upheaval.

Cuba's electoral system, for instance, was modelled on the USA. Restricting the vote to 100,000 men – mainly *peninsular* and Creole aristocracy – this disenfranchised women, Afro-Cubanos, and the lower classes (Gott 108) located predominantly within the eastern, impoverished, and majority Black provinces such as Oriente (Ferrer 19). This had a two-fold effect. First, US control of Cuban suffrage violated the antiracist principle enshrined in Cuban nationalism (*Latin American Perspectives* 8), catalysing resentment amongst Afro-Cubanos as Washington perpetuated disproportionate political representation and the racist-elitist status quo instituted by Madrid (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 52-54). Second, American manipulation of the electoral system elevated Washington annexationist sympathisers – the elite (Pérez-Stable 21) – to prioritise American interests in Cuban politics.

Though US candidates fared poorly in the 1900 municipal election (McGillivray 75), making annexation undesirable to Washington due to its potential conflict with perseverant Cuban nationalists (Sweig 11), the systematic limitation of suffrage to those compliant with Washington legitimised the post-Madrid precedent: only American sanction would cultivate political clout in republican Cuba, producing a foreign-centric politic that stoked nationalistic resentment.

The 1901 Platt Amendment (Kapcia 60-61) further ensconced this culture of American reliance for political advancement. Granting Washington the right to intervene in Cuba to preserve independence, life, property, and liberty (*National Archives and Records Administration*), Platt became a political actor on the island (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 152-153), as evident after the Moderate Palma's 1905 (Gott 116) fraudulent electoral victory (Pérez-Stable 31). In response, Liberals revolted in the *Guerrita de Agosto*, destroying foreign property to trigger American intervention and force political change as Palma appealed to Washington for political security (Gott 116). Amalgamated, this turbulence eventuated in American occupation of Cuba from 1906 until the 1909 Liberal victory (Sweig 12). In effect, intervention obstructed natural political succession by electorate action (Pérez-Stable 32), ingraining reliance on Washington for Cuban political functionality: corrupt regimes began to exploit Platt's clause for military interference amidst internal dissent to ensure political continuity; opposition to attack American property to stimulate intervention and force political ascendancy (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 154). Washington's occupation of Cuba in 1912 and 1917-23 to suppress the Independent Party of Colour's anti-racist revolt against Delgado (Lievesley 60-61) and Liberal *caudillo* and Afro-Cubano attacks (McGillivray 65-66) on American property during labour strikes (Gott 127-128), exemplifies this.

Furthermore, critically, long-term dependence on Plattist intervention incentivised parties to appeal to Washington's interests to gain its backing, suppressing Cuban needs deemed unlucrative to the power—such as economic reformism beyond the sugar monoculture to elevate the majority destitute non-elite proletariat in the predominantly eastern locale (Pollitt 320)—and spurring massive social resentment, as seen in the rise of anti-Plattist sentiment (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 175) in tandem with the normalisation of intervention by the 1920s (Benjamin 79-80).

Consequently, Ferrer postulates that US intervention in 1898 produced revolutionary conditions as Cuba suffered a "revolution unfinished" (Ferrer 197). Benjamin further posits that after 1898, Cuban nationalism became anti-Yankee (Benjamin 99). Both Ferrer and Benjamin aptly highlight the seeding of vitriolic anti-foreign, anti-Yankee nationalism amongst the non-elite populace in 1898 due to Washington's subversion of the *Independentista* vision; ensuing intervention was a hallmark of Cuba's persisting foreign dominance, echoing Madrid's imperial control and fuelling nationalistic revolutionary sentiment. This is especially evident in the rise of major revolutionary parties, such as the Cuban Communist Party in 1925 (Farber 37) and ABC Revolutionary Party (ABC) in 1931 (Lievesley 73) with anti-Platt, anti-imperialistic, and pro-Cuban policy lines, and Machado's election on an anti-Platt platform in 1924 (Kapcia 70). Nevertheless, contrasting Ferrer, a unified, anti-foreign nationalistic burgeoning and revolutionary conditions comparable to 1898 only emerged in 1933.

Machado had established dictatorial rule in 1928 (Gott 131) and acquiesced to Cuba's Washington-centric political culture, perpetuating Platt for American financial support to maintain his regime (Sweig 13). Contextualised within Cuba's economic peril in the Great Depression wrought by over-dependence on American trade (Benjamin 92-93), the urban student-and-worker-led (Kapcia 69) and middle-class-supported 1933 anti-Machado

revolution (Benjamin 83-84, 94) – which constituted the foundation to 1953 (Pérez Jr. *"Views From Abroad"* 88-90) – can therefore be viewed as a mass, unified demonstration of nationalism resonant with 1898 against Washington's convolution of Cuban polity, economy, and society, establishing a revolutionary undercurrent to Cuba's political domain.

Subsequently, continued American intervention in Cuban politics after Platt's 1934 abrogation by Grau (Pérez-Stable 40) intensified the potency of populist anti-Yankee nationalism, propelling revolutionary action to 1953. Washington's refusal to recognise Grau's reformist administration led to the installation of Mendieta's Washington-adjacent regime (Sweig 17), re-entrenching Cuba's stagnated, foreign-dominated, and corrupt polity that persisted through sequential Batista, Grau, and Prío presidencies (Thomas *"Origins"* 453, 457-458). This galvanised significant nationalistic opposition, as evident in the 1947 inauguration of the anti-corrupt, anti-Washington *Ortodoxo* party. Correspondingly, Washington's support for the non-elite, pro-American Batista (McGillivray 230) in his 1952 coup-installed dictatorship (Lievesley 10) eliminated legitimate routes to express anti-Washington nationalism, impelling Castro's violent 1953 revolutionary attempt to emancipate Cuba from its foreign-dominated and politically turbulent conditions (Castro).

Thus, American dominance and dependence institutionalised within Cuba's polity limited the scope of Cuban sovereignty and prevented the formation of "Cuba first". This inflamed visceral anti-Yankee nationalism as Cuba remained subverted by foreign rule, driving desires for true independence by extirpating American control.

Washington's dominance over the Cuban economy

From the 1790s, Cuba's economy developed into a sugar monoculture (Benjamin 11). Sugar production rose 18-fold from 1825-95 (Politt 320), engendering dependence upon sugar's progress for Cuba's prosperity (Fagen 81). However, foreign forces – predominantly American – dominated sugar, with an estimated 80% of Cuban sugar mills foreign-owned and 95% of sugar exports directed to the USA by 1895 (Sweig 9). Hence, Pérez-Stable postulates that sugar hegemony and its attraction of Western investment transformed Cuba into a foreign-dominated, self-perpetuating, enclave economy (Pérez-Stable 1-4). Though, by 1895, American encroachment upon Cuban sugar was only in its embryonic stages, the burgeoning economic dependence of Cuba upon American economic forces is evident in the impact of the 1894 Wilson-Gorman Tariff Act, which established a 40% tariff rate ad valorem on Cuban exports entering the USA, galvanising a 79.5% decline in Cuban sugar production from 1894-96 (Figure 1.0) (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 62-63, 74). This devastated the Cuban economy: unemployment amongst *colonos* and *hacendados* surged (Pérez-Stable 2); food prices skyrocketed (Figure 1.1) (McGillivray 35), rooting the impoverishment of the rural, working, and agricultural classes that persisted throughout the republican era.

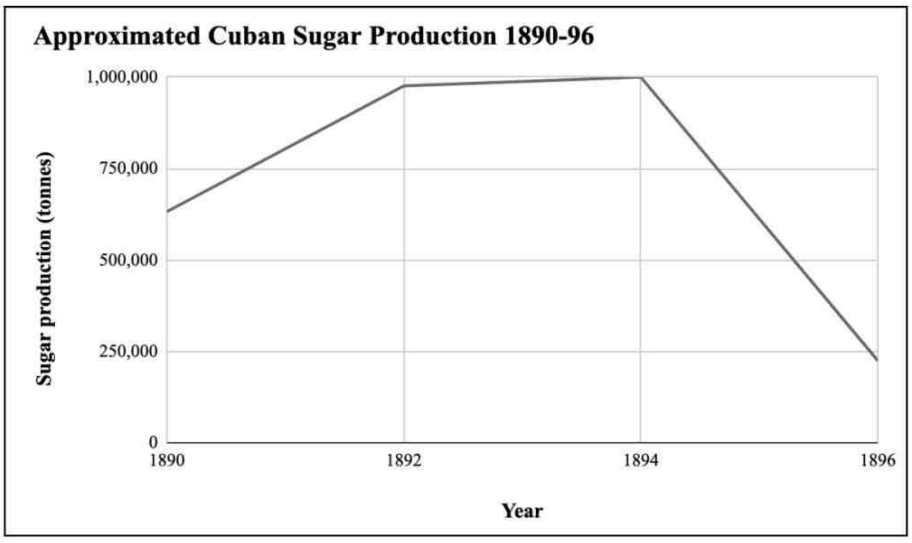


Figure 1.0: Approximated Cuban sugar production from 1890-96 (Pérez Jr. 62-63, 74).

Food prices in Cuba before and after the U.S. Wilson-Gorman Act		
Product	**Price per 100 kilos (USD)**	
	1893-1894	**1894-1895**
Wheat	0.30	3.95
Flour	1.00	4.75
Corn	0.25	3.95
Meal	0.25	4.75

Figure 1.1: Food prices in Cuba before and after the U.S. Wilson-Gorman Act (McGillivray 35).

In forming an export-market economy for Washington (Farber 9-10), Cuba bequeathed itself to American market forces that determined its pace of development. In the short-term, this dependence bolstered Cuba's economic growth and modernisation (Kapcia 61). The 1903 Reciprocity Treaty granted a 20% tariff reduction on Cuban exports and a 24-40% tariff reduction on American imports (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 121-122), incentivising American investment into Cuba, which reached $750 million by 1925 (Farber 8-9), spurring 17-fold sugar expansion (Pérez-Stable 2) and massive infrastructure construction as Washington provided 90% of electric services and 50% of railways to Cuba by the 1940s (Sweig 18). Yet, such investment predominantly served the movement of sugar products to market, yielding disproportionate economic development that produced minor enclave economies within Cuba. Beyond Havana, this is exemplified by Chaparra, Oriente's largest sugar mill. Focalised American investment propelled Chaparra's self-sufficient modernisation (McGillivray 89-90) while Oriente remained impoverished, fuelling mass disillusionment amongst Oriente's majority destitute rural *colonos*, including Castro (McGillivray 242), founding 1953's aim for sugar reform (Castro).

Furthermore, geographically sporadic enclave development was unstable itself as American policy fluctuated. The implementation of the protective 1931 Smoot-Hawley Tariff (Farber 10) during the Great Depression crippled Cuba economically, precipitating a decline in sugar production by $160 million; wages by 50-75% (Gott 134); and national revenue by 414 million pesos from 1929-32 (McGillivray 204). This spurred massive strikes amongst

non-elite strata (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 180), evident in the March 1930 200,000-strong demonstration led by the urban and rural proletariat that catalysed 1933 (Pérez-Stable 38). Hence, US encroachment into the Cuban economy placed the island at the mercy of American political and economic developments, destroying vestigial notions of independent stability as Cuban economic vitality and modernisation remained reliant on foreign forces, intensifying revolutionary sentiment amongst disaffected rural and urban non-elite.

Moreover, the influx of American capital to persist American hegemony over Cuba (Kapcia 61) galvanised Washington's political interventionism to protect her economic interests, perpetuating Cuba's foreign political dominance. The American General Crowder, for instance, governed Cuba in 1920 after labour strikes syphoned $200 million from American profits (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 160-161, 167-168). Thus, Plattist intervention, *impelled* by economic investment (Kapcia 61), eliminated avenues for non-elite political expression to herald natural political succession and critical reformism to ameliorate socioeconomic turmoil. Critically, this catalysed the preservation of sugar monoculture over economic diversification (Benjamin 68-69) due to its lucrativeness to Washington (Thomas "*Origins*" 462-463), aggravating the plight of rural agrarian proletariat in American-investment-absent economic regions and urban workers aggrieved by fluctuating sugar, producing revolutionary conditions amongst these economically disillusioned classes.

Subsequently, Pollitt posits that the devastating impacts of economic downturns (specifically Washington's Great Depression tariffs) inflamed nationalistic sentiment that culminated in the 1933 Revolution (Pollitt 321). Contextualised within Thomas' argument that Castro's revolution was the product of unfinished revolutions, including the upsurge of 1933 (Thomas "*Origins*" 460), in evaluating Pollitt, Washington's perceived culpability in producing the instability of Cuba's economy, and the more significant role of Cuban regimes in perpetuating

Washington's economic imperialism after 1933 as American investment reached an additional $657 million by 1952 (Foran 18), stoked anti-imperialistic nationalistic fervour amongst long-impoverished rural and urban proletariat disgruntled by disproportionate, fluctuating development, producing desires for a radical solution to Cuba's economic conundrum (Farber 33). This rising fervour is particularly evident in the new – eventually primary – mode of rebellion that emerged during the 1933 and forthcoming 1959 revolutions: burning sugarcane fields to devastate American capital (McGillivray 2) and uproot foreign influence to produce a Cuba-centric economy and politic.

Hence, nationalistic frustration eventuated in support for Castro's populist land and sugar reforms after 1953 (Castro). However, from a more nuanced outlook, the effect of US economic imperialism can be deemed as that of a catalyst; as highlighted by Sweig, the revolution aimed to challenge the economic status quo of the USA, not eliminate it, to emancipate Cuba from sugar monoculture's bonds upon political independence, reformism, and economic development (Sweig 26). American hegemony in the Cuban economy thus exacerbated Cuba's present nationalistic political, economic, and social distress instead of producing it: it cultivated the Plattism that subsumed Cuban political autonomy and intensified the instability and widespread penury amongst non-elite in rural and urban abodes wrought by myopic sugar centrality.

Cuba's internal weaknesses

Political instability within Cuba

Albeit Platt engendered political reliance on Washington, the Cuban polity itself was burdened by structural weaknesses, including endemic corruption (Jany 3) and militaristic dictatorial rule (Julien 178-179). These flaws undermined the *Independentista* vision of an equitable, democratic system (Suchliki 33-34), ingraining instability that drove support for radical political opponents vowing change, namely Castro, subsequently producing revolutionary conditions by 1953 (Jany 3-4).

Though Washington's 1902 manipulation established the precedent for electoral fraudulence institutionalised within Cuba's polity, Palma perpetuated this corruption to secure his 1906 presidency, purging Liberals from municipal governments (Pérez-Stable 30-31) and engineering a swindled election (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 153). Triggering the Liberal revolt in protest (Sweig 12), political turmoil was only resolved by the 1909 transfer of power (Gott 115-116). Pérez-Stable, in analysing, argues that Palma's betrayal signified the demise of the *Independentista* civilian republic (Pérez-Stable 31) – she is convincing in two modes.

First, the successive fraudulent elections reinforced the corruption already embedded within Cuba – instituted by Madrid (Gott 114) – forming a solipsistic politic centred around the interests of parties and leaders instead of national development (Benjamin 71-74). Such is evident in 1909's aftermath (McGillivray 162). Despite its outcry against Moderate corruption, the new Liberal regime instituted sinecures and cronyism to consolidate its power (Sweig 12). In turn, beyond discrediting the party, this entrenched the autarchic nature of Cuban politics, as parties neglected democratic reform to preserve power, with corruption henceforth underlying *every* national election from 1912-52 (Farber 49). Furthermore, the

perpetuation of electoral fraud critically nullified the electoral ballot (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 151-152), disenfranchising non-elite Cubans lacking political ties to the Cuban politic (Farber 49) and hence removing their only legitimate means to extirpate self-serving corrupt regimes to stimulate political development. This enabled the rise of increasingly megalomaniacal and authoritarian leaders without checks, such as Machado (Gott 127-130) and Batista (Thomas "*Origins*" 453). These regimes engendered massive resentment amongst each stratum of Cuban society, from *Independentista* veterans to urban youth, as they stood as humiliating symbols of the unrealised *Independentista* equitable democracy that would have empowered the average Cubano (Suchliki 33-34). Given the elimination of legal methods for political expression, including strikes suppressed by Plattist intervention (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 160-161) and limited suffrage, this catalysed increasingly radical opposition action, such as the proletariat-executed burning of sugarcane, to simulate political dialogue (McGillivray 80), further undermining the republic's democratic framework and propelling turbulent revolutionary conditions.

Second, the 1909 Liberal election via force in the 1906 revolt (McGillivray 162) entrenched Cuban polity's militarisation, legitimising insurrection to transfer power and violent suppression to preserve power, further desecrating democratic principles. Such conditions, for instance, yielded the 1933 "Sergeant's Revolt" to remove Machado (Sweig 15-16) following his assassination of some 150 *Confederación Nacional Obrera Cubana* (CNOC) and Cuban Communist Party (PCC) opponents by 1927 (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 179). Subsequently, the institution of a violent modus operandi for power alternance effectively transformed Cuba's polity into a militaristic domain that, combined with a vacuous electoral system of 'checks and balances', cultivated the conditions for dictatorial rule, as evident in Batista's 1952 military coup to seize power from Prío (Thomas

"*Origins*" 453), subsuming impending elections and insubstantial opposition, ending constitutional rule and the republic with sheer force (Sweig 19).

Thus, Pérez-Stable is convincing in recognising the impact of 1906 in establishing the foundation for an unstable, militarised polity that directly contradicted Martí's vision for a stable and democratic Cuba (Sierra). Such instability awakened an anti-corruption (Benjamin 132) and anti-dictatorial (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 46) layer of Cuban nationalism – exemplified by the anti-corruption demands of the 1933 anti-Machado revolution (McGillivray 205) – that fuelled support for radical revolutionaries such as Castro by 1953, who, by attempting to oust Batista (Pérez-Stable 52), epitomised the struggle to free Cuba from its turbulent political trajectory. However, in contrast to Pérez-Stable, Cuba's corrupt political culture was only rooted by Palma and subsequent leaders; conversely, culpability for its seeding is vested in Washington's electoral manipulation to persist political dominance in Cuba in 1902. Moreover, Washington's prolonged financial support for corrupt regimes incentivised maintaining this defective politic, inflaming anti-corrupt, anti-dictatorial, and critically, anti-Yankee nationalism. Hence, though the Cuban political system was flawed from the outset, such convolution arose not from solipsistic political leaders but Washington's intervention.

Internal structural economic weaknesses

Sugar, by 1925, constituted 50% of Cuba's agricultural output; 28% of its GNP; and 23% of its employment (Pérez-Stable 3) following an 8% per annum increase in production from 1850 (Thomas *"The Pursuit of Freedom"* 432) and expansion from Havana and Matanzas in the west Camagüey and Oriente in the east, dominating island-wide proletariat (McGillivray xvi). Superficially prosperous, Cuban exports accounted for 23% of the global cane and beet sugar markets (Pollitt 320). Yet, underlying structural defects within the industry catalysed its instability, driving the economic disillusionment of Cuba's rural and urban proletariat. Albeit American market forces perpetuated sugar monoculture, the internal disarray of Cuba's economy in centralising itself around the sugar industry, as posited by Thomas, provides the origins of the revolution (Thomas "*Origins*" 449) and Castro's – himself a son of a *colono* in rural Oriente (McGillivray 77) – sugar, worker, and land reformist appeal (Castro).

Poor labour security due to sugar fluctuation economically disenfranchised Cuba's proletariat, engendering widespread labour unrest (Kapcia 69) that drove support for revolutionary reformist policies. For instance, the sugar season's *zafra's* length declined from 300 days in 1900 to 95 days by the mid-1940s (Farber 49), precipitating unstable labour conditions: unemployment rose to 20.7% during the sugar off-season; a third of the population – 1.7 million – failed to hold full-time jobs by the 1950s (Pérez-Stable 12). Compounded by the majority foreign ownership of Cuban mills (Benjamin 121-122) and the irregularity of global sugar demand – with prices for a standard four million tonnes of sugar varying between $200 and $1000 million from 1920-58 (Thomas "*Origins*" 452-453) – from a micro-perspective, this produced an unconducive financial climate for the average rural Cuban *colono* and *hacendado*, who lacked both a stable income and land to generate income,

and was thus dependent upon foreign-dominated and forever-shifting sugar markets for sustenance (Castro). Correspondingly, from a macro-perspective, sugar dominance heralded a knock-on effect upon workers in nonsugar industries, as manufacturers limited product sales and wage payments to *zafra* (Thomas "*Origins*" 452) due to increased economic cash flow. Cumulatively, sugar centrality debilitated Cuban economic functionality, disenfranchising urban, rural, and industry-wide proletariat. Amalgamated by political negligence for critical industrial diversification and labour security reforms due to sugar's lucrativeness to Washington, this spurred massive proletariat resentment, with 200,000 workers joining the CNOC to pressure Machado for reforms by 1925 (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 171-174), in an economically-impelled, pro-Cuban-worker nationalistic front.

Yet, under Cuba's anti-democratic and pro-Washington political atmosphere, labour dissent was rapidly quashed (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 179), as exemplified by the CNOC's 1925 prohibition, stifling political expression and intensifying anti-Yankee nationalism perceptively culpable for anti-Cuban politics and economics (McGillivray 151). As Cuban regimes beyond Grau's transient four-month radical government failed to institute sweeping economic reform (Sweig 16), such nationalism translated into working-class support for radical, pro-proletariat, and nationalistic parties, such as the Popular Socialist Party (the 1943-reorganised PCC) (Pérez-Stable 45-47), thus proliferating revolutionary sentiment amenable to a radical solution to Cuba's socioeconomic turbulence. As such, Castro's economically-reformist revolutionary laws (Castro) appealed to this disaffected, revolutionary-acquiescent base, producing proletariat revolutionary fervour by 1953.

Underlying nationalistic social mobilisation

Finally, though American influence and Cuban republican flaws critically spurred revolutionary conditions by 1953, one may conversely argue that long-term, latent nationalistic mobilisation of disillusioned Afro-Cubanos (Ferrer 197) and students (Fagen 73) driven to form Martí's true *Independentista* republic (Ferrer 198) heralded the inevitability of revolution by 1953. Though Afro-Cubanos were predominantly politically active in early republican years (Gott 125), students emerged as political actors in the 1920s and 1930s (Pérez-Stable 19) – amongst whom crucially stood Castro. Amalgamated, these groups transformed into catalysts for revolution: a hotbed of nationalistic consciousness buttressing Castro's radical revolutionary vision by 1953.

Afro-Cubanos were promised an antiracist republic (*Latin American Perspectives* 8) in the *Cubanidad* put forth by *Independentista* leaders – including the Afro-Cubano Maceo (Fagen 70-71), Gómez, and Martí (Ferrer 8-9; Martí and Gómez). Hence empowered and mobilised, Afro-Cubanos comprised some 60% of the Liberation Army by 1898 (Ferrer 3). Yet, Washington – contextualised within Jim Crow (Sweig 32) – contrarily reinforced the racist-elite status quo, reigniting disillusionment amongst Afro-Cubanos (Lievesley 60-61) that transformed into visceral reformist fervour – predominantly amongst Liberation Army veterans (Pérez-Stable 25) – motivated to achieve racial equality by political mobilisation. This is demonstrated by the *Partido Independiente de Color*'s (PIC) inauguration in 1907 by Evaristo Estenoz, a former slave and war veteran (Gott 122). Designed to champion racial equality, the PIC harnessed latent Afro-Cubano disenfranchisement into a revolutionary force roused to achieve the *Independentista* antiracist Cuba. However, fears of a 'black' revolution akin to Haiti by Washington resulted in its censorship (Sweig 31), precipitating the PIC's May 1912 protest with 4000-7000 Afro-Cubanos (Lievesley 60-61). Though violently

suppressed with some 5000 Afro-Cubanos deaths (Pérez-Stable 33), the protest nonetheless highlighted the power of underlying Afro-Cubano disaffection (Lievesley 60-61), capable of coalescence into a potent revolutionary force. Albeit 1912 hindered Afro-Cubano willingness to engage in Cuban politics with the same vigour (Gott 125), the glaring display of its power placed black mobilisation at the forefront of revolutionary agendas, including the PCC, CNOC (Lievesley 34), and though implicit, Castro's economic reforms to elevate majority black, destitute provinces such as Oriente (Castro). Critically, efforts to elevate Afro-Cubanos in revolutionary circles thus revived Marti's antiracist *Independentista* dogma within the revolutionary camp, fuelling Cuba-centrism that intensified brewing anti-Yankee nationalism, catalysing 1953.

By contrast, student and intellectual mobilisation emerged during economic deterioration and ingrained political corruption (Pérez-Stable 38) of the 1920s. Drawing from anti-imperialistic, anti-American (Sweig 13-14), and anti-dictatorial resentment (Benjamin 83), students of the University of Havana established the *Directorio Revolucionario Estudiantil* (DEU) (Thomas "Origins" 459); and coalesced the ABC, PCC, and CNOC to counter Machado's perpetuation of Cuban economic and political stagnation (Pérez-Stable 38). Consequently, students emerged as active forces within the Cuban polity, creating and upholding opposition amidst disenfranchisement and repression to stimulate Cuban progress and political change. The extent of their influence is evident in 1933. Beyond the rebellion's origins in the majority-student ABC and PCC (Gott 134), students colluded with the military to orchestrate the "Sergeants' Revolt" in September, forcing Machado's departure and alternance of power (Benjamin 88).

Hence, Benjamin postulates that the emergence of students as political agents by 1933 was critical in igniting a potent Cuban nationalism, echoing Martí's, driven to achieve stable and true Cuban independence amongst a new generation (Benjamin 131). Although the

post-Machado Grau-Guiteras regime failed (Pérez Jr. *"Ties of Singular Intimacy"* 194-195), and student parties fragmented along ideological lines – evidenced by Chibás' 1947 establishment of the Ortodoxo Party from the Auténtico umbrella (Thomas "Origins" 459), somewhat diminishing their influence, her line of argumentation is well-founded. Students imbued with a nationalistic spirit and Martí's writings (Jany 2) – including antiracist doctrine – constituted a valuable nationalistic hotbed ripe for revolutionary activity, directly galvanising 1953, with the Moncada assault led by students mobilised by Castro to remove Batista and achieve an equitable "Cuba first" (Julien 179).

Consequently, disillusioned students rebirthed the Cuba Libre movement in Cuba's mid-to-late republican era (Ferrer 198), reigniting Martí's *Independentista* nationalism to ameliorate Cuban political, economic, and social turmoil that drove Cuba towards revolution and progress by 1953.

Conclusion

In 1895, Martí forewarned the threat of impending American political interference and economic cohesion with Cuba (Sierra). His fears were soon realised by American intervention in 1898 that extirpated *Independentistas* from the achievement of Cuban imperial liberty (Sweig 10), forming the precedent for Washington's political and economic dominance over Cuba which persisted through its republican years.

Though political-Plattist intervention and American economic control did not birth the fundamental political and economic issues afflicting Cuba's republic – namely rife political corruption, a holdover of Madrid's imperialism, and economic stagnation due to sugar centrality – Washington perpetuated the convolution of Cuba's political and economic systems, blockading critical reformism to uphold its interests. Compounded by Washington's role in hindering the establishment of *Independentista* Cuba, as racist elitism persisted; foreign capital and interests were prioritised over Cuba's majority disenfranchised proletariat; and puppet dictators implanted, desecrating democracy and entrenching a solipsistic, suppressive militaristic politic, unequal US-Cuban relations engendered near-ubiquitous visceral anti-Yankee nationalism that transformed into a potent revolutionary consciousness by 1953.

Yet, in evaluating the historiographical branches presented at the outset of this study, American influence only insofar drove the political and economic strife that yielded revolutionary fervour; self-serving parties perpetuated and magnified such turmoil for transient political clout and sugar's myopic prosperity, fuelling disillusionment with Cuba's republic. Subsequently, foreign-catalysed and Cuban-perpetuated instability galvanised mass disenchantment across student, working, and non-elite strata, awakening nascent *Independentista* nationalism for a Cuba-centric, independent republic that heralded desires

for radical change to ameliorate Cuba's instability. Critically, this both precipitated revolutionary organisation – exemplified by the establishment of the PSP and Ortodoxo Party to combat Washington-centrism and political corruption – *and* provided a widespread hotbed of nationalistic revolutionary support for Castro to eventually harness through paradigmatic reformist revolutionary laws that, amalgamated, formed revolutionary conditions for 1953.

Thus, prolonged unequal US-Cuban relations, upheld by inner forces, conclusively catalysed revolutionary conditions by 1953.

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